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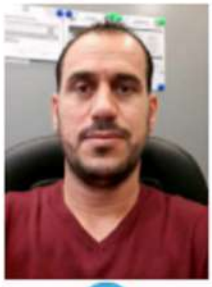

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ORIGINAL PAPER

How Resilient Are Equity Markets? Efficiency of Islamic and Conventional Indices During COVID-19

Mohamad Husam Helmi[1] · Muhammad Shehryar[2] · Syed Muhammad Abdul Rehman Shah[3] · Maslinawati Mohamad[2]

Received: 14 March 2025 / Revised: 2 November 2025 / Accepted: 4 December 2025
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Abstract

The outbreak of COVID-19 has brought significant uncertainty to financial markets worldwide, prompting renewed interest in the efficiency of various equity indices. This study explores how Islamic and conventional equity indices in eight Asian markets responded to the pandemic in terms of informational efficiency. By applying the Automatic Portmanteau (AQ) Test and the Automatic Variance Ratio (AVR) approach, we assess the validity of the Martingale Difference Hypothesis and the Random Walk Hypothesis across three periods: before, during, and after the pandemic. Our results show that, over the entire sample period, conventional indices were weak-form efficient 62.5% of the time, compared to 37.5% for Islamic indices. Conventional indices generally exhibited higher weak-form efficiency in both the pre-pandemic and post-pandemic periods, while both types of indices displayed similar weak-form efficiency during the pandemic itself. These findings suggest that the efficiency of Asian stock markets is sensitive to major global disruptions, with both Islamic and conventional indices affected during times of crisis. The study offers practical insights for investors and policymakers seeking to understand market behavior and resilience in the face of unprecedented events.

Keywords Efficient market hypothesis · Random walk hypothesis · Martingale-Difference hypothesis · Islamic finance · COVID-19 pandemic · Asian equity markets

JEL classification G14 · G21 · I18 · O53

Extended author information available on the last page of the article

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The Role of Weather Anomalies in Shaping Investor Sentiment and Stock Market Performance: A Conceptual Analysis

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ABSTRACT

This conceptual paper presents a theoretical explanation for understanding the impact of weather anomaly on stock market dynamics and investor behavior. Weather anomalies, including unusual temperature variations, extreme precipitation, humidity, cloudiness, sunshine, wind speed, and severe weather events, can disrupt investors mood, emotions, feelings, and behavior, which are subsequently reflected in share market returns. Current paper starts with an ample review of prevailing literature on the impact of various weather-related factors upon investor behavior as well as equity markets, highlighting significant findings and methodological approaches while identifying gaps and inconsistencies. It then presents an enhanced conceptual rationalization that incorporates psychological and behavioral finance perspectives, providing a significant view of how investor sentiment and market reactions to weather anomalies may lead to abnormal returns. This framework challenges the assumption of strong market efficiency by suggesting that systematic and seasonal patterns in investor behavior, influenced by emotions, cognitive biases, and weather factors, can amplify the financial impacts of weather anomalies on equity markets. The paper also explores the practical implications of weather anomaly for investment strategies, risk management, and market regulation, accenting the necessity for adaptive tactics in optimal portfolio management. Finally, it outlines routes for upcoming research, advocating for empirical studies and investigate the underlying causes of weather anomalies. This paper aims to enhance the understanding of weather anomalies' role in financial markets and contribute to the broader discourse on market efficiency and environmental finance. The findings are particularly relevant for investors, mutual funds, brokers, practitioners, policymakers, and regulators.

Keywords: Weather Anomaly, Stock Market, Behavioral Finance, Environmental Finance

INTRODUCTION

The Efficient Market Hypothesis (E.M.H) claims that investors could not make abnormal returns, rather normal returns will only be possible by following the market (Fama, 1970; Iordache, 2024). In the contradiction, shareholders are still capable to get the above-average returns due to some financial anomalies (Al-Khazali & Mirzaei, 2017; Steinborn, 2024), as the school of Behavioral Finance challenged the E.M.H that investors and markets do not consistently exhibit rational behavior; instead, psychological factors and investor behavior can influence decision-making and price volatility, leading to abnormal returns based on individual perceptions, moods, and sentiments (Kahneman, 1979; Shleifer, 2000; Fromlet, 2001; Shiller, 2003). So, it will be important for the investors to know about the impact of different financial anomalies on the behavior of investors and stock performance for better investment decisions in order to earn abnormal returns.

According to Shehadeh and Zheng (2023), a financial anomaly is an unusual or abnormal event in the financial market that lets investors make big profits by spotting different seasonal patterns. This goes against the well-known theory of standard finance. These anomalies demonstrate market inefficiencies since they alter investor psychology and allow them to achieve anomalous profits (Bassiouny et al., 2023). Financial anomalies were separated into technical, fundamental, and calendar or seasonal anomalies (Al-Khazali & Mirzaei, 2017). A seasonal calendar anomaly, which states that investors can earn huge returns by buying on certain calendar time

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Random Walk Hypothesis: An Empirical Comparison of Shari'ah and Non-Shari'ah Capital Markets of Pakistan and China

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ABSTRACT

The instant research comparatively determines the weak-form informational efficiency of Shari'ah and corresponding non-Shari'ah equity indices of Pakistan and China by testing the Random Walk Hypothesis. For this purpose, this study employed the Automatic Variance Ratio on the daily index data for the time ranging from 1st July 2009 to 30th June 2018. The findings of the study show that the Shari'ah index of Pakistan (KMI-30) is informational efficient in weak-form but the Shari'ah index of China (FTSE Shariah China Index) is not efficient. On the other hand, as far as the non-Shari'ah indices are concerned, KSE-100 Index (Pakistan) is not weak-form efficient, but the Shanghai Composite Index (China) is efficient. So, it is determined that in Pakistan, the Shari'ah equity market is weak form efficient during the sample period but its counterpart non-Shari'ah equity market is not efficient. Further, in China, the non-Shari'ah stock market is weak-form efficient, but its Shari'ah stock market is not efficient. In the nutshell, it is concluded that the Shari'ah indices are also witnessing efficiency along with non-Shari'ah indices, and Shari'ah indices viz-a-viz Shari'ah stocks can be good option for optimum investment.

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1. Introduction

After the Subprime Mortgage Crises of 2007-2009, researchers and practitioners thought about another architecture and system, i.e. The Islamic Financial System, which will accommodate the world to reduce the occurrence as well as the intensity of said crises ahead (Chapra, 2008). The modalities of the Islamic Financial System are mentioned in a crystal-clear manner in the Holy Qur'an (A holy book of the last Holy Prophet Muhammad) and Sunn'ah (practices of Holy Prophet

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BEYOND THE EFFICIENT MARKET HYPOTHESIS: A CONCEPTUAL INQUIRY INTO CALENDAR ANOMALIES

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Keywords: behavioral finance; calendar anomalies; equity investors; financial markets; market efficiency

Abstract

Calendar anomalies, including the day-of-the-week effect, week-of-the-month effect, and January effect, persistently contest the efficient market hypothesis (EMH), which asserts that asset prices completely incorporate available information. This study reviews previous research to explore why these predictable patterns persist despite technological progress and market transparency. By combining perspectives from EMH, behavioral finance, and the adaptive market hypothesis (AMH), the study explains the temporal variability of these anomalies across different market contexts. Results demonstrate that investor sentiment, cognitive biases, and socio-cultural influences largely contribute to their persistence. The discourse encompasses practical implications for investment strategy, portfolio management, and regulatory surveillance, particularly highlighting Shariah-compliant and emerging markets where anomalies may display unique attributes. Investors, mutual funds, and brokers can gain benefit through generating higher returns.

INTRODUCTION

Calendar anomalies have been consistently recorded as enduring irregularities in the economy, prompting unresolved questions over the legitimacy of the efficient market hypothesis (EMH). Their reappearance across many times, asset classes, and market situations, notably the global financial crisis of 2008 and the COVID-19 epidemic, has shown the limitations of market efficiency. These

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Original Article

Blockchain in Trust with Reputation Management for Financial Stock Market Using Distributed Ledger Technology and Bayesian Theory Based on Fault Tolerance Model

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Ravi Kumar Bommisetti[1], Bhavana K. Raj[2], A. V. V. S. Subbalakshmi[3], Muhammad Shehryar[4] and Sinh Duc Hoang[5]

Abstract

Blockchain, which is at the heart of bitcoin and other digital currencies, is a game-changing technology, particularly in the stock market and financial technology. These characteristics make blockchain adoption appealing for enhancing information security, privacy and reliability in a variety of scenarios. This article develops the trust with reputation-based management for the financial stock market. Here distributed ledger technology (DLT) has been integrated for implementing the ledger in which data is stored across a network of decentralized nodes. By this, proof-based ledger has been maintained with transparency, traceability and security. DLT here used is based on trust design in mitigating the malicious activities of the financial stock marketing technology. Then using Bayesian theory based on the fault tolerance (BDLT_FT) model has been used in improving the efficiency of DLT and financial technology. This acts as the protocol which reduces energy consumption and enhance network scalability and security in digital transactions like cryptocurrency The financial data related to blockchain cryptocurrency were collected between the time period 2000 and 2020. The dataset of the stock market is evaluated under the fault tolerance model with statistical analysis. The statistical evaluation of financial data with developed BDLT_FT expressed that there is no association between the fault tolerance and the classification error.

Keywords

Blockchain, stock exchange market, financial technology, trust, DLT, BDLTFT

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Are Asian *Sharī'ah*-Compliant Equity Indices Predictable

*Muhammad Umer Quddoos
**Muhammad Shehryar
***Asif Yaseen

Abstract

This study examines the informational efficiency in the weak-form of Islamic (*Sharī'ah*-compliant) equity indices of selected countries by testing the Martingale Difference Hypothesis and the Random Walk Hypothesis. The study applies Automatic Portmanteau Test (AQ) and Automatic Variance Ratio Test (AVR) on daily index return from 1st July 2009 to 30th June 2018. All indices appear to be informationally efficient (weak-form) as per the AQ Test, except FTSE Malaysia EMAS *Sharī'ah* Index and Jakarta Islamic Index. As per results of AVR Test, Islamic indices of China and Malaysia were not found weak-form of efficient. Whereas, as per the combined results of both AQ and AVR Tests, it is found that only three indices rejected the weak-form of efficiency and five indices are consistent with weak-form of efficiency. So, it can be concluded that Asian Islamic indices have the sufficient level of tendency towards the informational efficiency in weak form. Findings of this study will help the academicians, regulators, and policy-makers understand the application of market efficiency hypothesis, and its major aspects that need further investigation.

Keywords: *Sharī'ah*-compliant equity indices, Efficient Market, Martingale Difference Hypothesis, Random Walk Hypothesis.

JEL Classification Numbers: G14, G15

Introduction:

After the severe wave of global Subprime Mortgage Crises (2007-2009), researchers and economists called for a new financial mechanism [1]. The Islamic Financial System (IFS) is based upon the principles of *Sharī'ah* (The code of conduct based on Islam). During the last many years, the Islamic financial services (e.g., Mudarabah, Musharakah, *Istīsnā'*, Salam, *Murabaḥā*, Takaful, *Ṣukūk*, etc.) have gotten immense attention, around the world, by *Sharī'ah*-complaint investors as well as by even non-muslim investors due to the Profit and Loss Sharing (PLS) modes of financing, adequate market discipline, and absence of derivatives which are missing in conventional financial system[2]. As PLS have merits/benefits over conventional[3]. Further, Siddiqi[4] concluded that the Global Financial Crises of 2007-2009

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[1] M Umer Chapra, "The Global Financial Crisis: Can Islamic Finance Help Minimize the Severity and Frequency of Such a Crisis in the Future," in *A Paper Presented at the Forum on the Global Financial Crisis at the Islamic Development Bank On*, vol. 25, 2008.

[2] Chapra.

[3] Haitham A Al-Zoubi and Aktham I Maghyereh, "The Relative Risk Performance of Islamic Finance: A New Guide to Less Risky Investments," *International Journal of Theoretical and Applied Finance* 10, no. 02 (2007): 235–49.

[4] Mohammad Nejatullah Siddiqi, "Current Financial Crisis and Islamic Economics," *IIUM Journal of Economics and Management* 16, no. 2 (2008): 125–32.

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The Puzzle of Informational Efficiency & Macroeconomic Variables: A Comparative Evidence in Shari'ah Stock Markets of Pakistan viz-a-viz Malaysia

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ABSTRACT

The present study examines the weak-form informational efficiency of the Shari'ah stock market of Pakistan and Malaysia. For this purpose, the study uses the daily index price data of the KSE Meezan Index (Pakistan) & FTSE Malaysia EMAS Shariah Index (Malaysia) for the time span starting from 1st July 2009 to 30th June 2019. By employing a more robust test namely Automatic Portmanteau Test (AQ Test) through testing the Martingale Difference Hypothesis, this study finds that KSE Meezan Index (KMI-30) was informationally efficient (weak-form) whereas FTSE Malaysia EMAS Shariah Index was not weak-form of efficient. Further, this research investigates the long-run relationship viz-a-viz short-run relationship among the returns of both Islamic stock markets and three macroeconomic variables (Exchange Rate, Inflation Rate, Interest Rate) of both said countries. In this connection, this study employs the Philips-Perron Test for stationary analysis, Johansen co-integration test, Vector Error Correction Model on the monthly time series data for the same said sample period. The statistical findings show that returns of both Shari'ah stock markets have a long-run association with said macroeconomic variables and have the co-integration or long-term association with long-run causality running from macroeconomic variables to the return of the Islamic stock market in both sample countries but the short-run association viz-a-viz short-run causality is not found.

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1. Introduction

The Financial System of a country has a vital significance for the smooth functioning of the economy as well as to allocate savings efficiently to ultimate users. The main pillars of a Financial System are Financial Instruments, Financial Markets, and Financial Institution. In this regard, a stock market has been one of the linchpin financial markets which play an important role as a secondary market for different buyers and sellers of equity. Many researchers found that the stock market, as well as the investing behavior, can be affected by different factors like informational

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Bringing Youth towards Entrepreneurship: A Field Experiment in Pakistan

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ABSTRACT

This study examines the causal effect of a one-day intervention, comprising motivation, information, knowledge, and role modelling, on entrepreneurial attitude, entrepreneurial intention, and entrepreneurial implementation intentions in a field experiment. A pre-test post-test design (N = 34) was used with 17 potential entrepreneurs in each group (control and experiment). The pre-test and post-test scores of the experiment group allowed the construction of a latent change model, which was tested by using multivariate linear regressions in partial least squares structural equation modelling (PLS-SEM). The results demonstrated a significant and positive effect of the intervention on entrepreneurial attitude, which increased entrepreneurial implementation intentions through entrepreneurial intention. The study's uniqueness is that it simultaneously examines the causal effect of the intervention on entrepreneurial attitude and the effect of resultant change in entrepreneurial attitude on entrepreneurial implementation intentions through entrepreneurial intention. Thus, the study examines the effect of intervention beyond entrepreneurial intention and explores the relationship between entrepreneurial intention and entrepreneurial implementation intentions. The theoretical implication of the study is that entrepreneurial intention mediates the effect of entrepreneurial attitude on entrepreneurial implementation intentions. Whereas the practical implication of the study is that youth graduating from universities and colleges can be made prefer entrepreneurship over wage employment through short interventions. Limitations have been discussed, and future recommendations have been proposed.

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1. Introduction

Entrepreneurship is central to economic growth and development, jobs creation and unemployment reduction (Faria, Cuestas, & Mourelle, 2010; Van Praag & Versloot, 2007). This has been validated in both developed and developing countries (Fritsch, 2004; Konings, 1995). By 1997, the Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT)'s graduates had formed nearly 4000 companies that provided jobs to 1.1 million. These companies had sales of $232 Billion, making them World's 24th largest economy independently (Oeconomiae, 2008). Similarly, A more recent report by MIT itself on the economic impact of companies founded by MIT graduates between 1950 and 2014 states that during this period MIT graduates had established more than 30000 companies that had 4.6 million employees and combined sales of $1.9 trillion, making them 10th biggest economy of the world approximately (Roberts, Murray, & Kim, 2019). Thus, entrepreneurship is extremely important in GDP growth and employment

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Una vez finalizado el proceso de admisión a los Programas de Doctorado de la Universidad Rey Juan Carlos, y comprobando que cumple con los requisitos necesarios para el acceso al mismo, quiero hacerle llegar mi más cordial enhorabuena por haber sido admitido para cursar los estudios de:

en la Universidad Rey Juan Carlos, con n. registro de universidades 56, durante el año académico 2024-25.

A fin de hacer efectiva la admisión deberá formalizar su matrícula, en las fechas establecidas y a través del sistema habilitado para ello en www.urjc.es/eid.

A la espera de su plena integración en la vida universitaria, le saluda cordialmente,

Dª. Maria del Pilar Abad Romero

Directora Escuela Internacional de Doctorado

Esta admisión está condicionada a que el alumno cumpla todos los requisitos legales establecidos para la matriculación en la Escuela Internacional de Doctorado de la Universidad Rey Juan Carlos.

UNIVERSITI TEKNOLOGI MARA
Institut Pengajian Siswazah

Our Reference : **500-IPSis (8/6/9)**
Date : **14 ذوالحجة 1445H**
21 Jun 2024

To Whom It May Concern

Dear Sir/Madam,

CONFIRMATION OF STUDENT'S STATUS AT UNIVERSITI TEKNOLOGI MARA (UiTM)

Name	:	**Shehryar Muhammad**
Student No	:	**2023621804**
IC/Passport No	:	**XX5155151**
Name & Programme Code	:	**DOCTOR OF PHILOSOPHY (ISLAMIC FINANCE AND MUAMALAT) (AR951)**
Mode of Learning	:	**Research**
Study Mode	:	**Full Time**
Faculty	:	**Accounting Research Institute**
Duration of study (Estimated)	:	**Min (2.5 years / 5 semesters), Max (7 years / 14 semesters)**

2. This letter is to certify that **Shehryar Muhammad** is enrolled as a postgraduate student in UiTM, for academic session beginning **October 2023**. The method of study for this program is by **research** and the student is expected to complete his study in **September 2025** academic session.

3. The Institute of Postgraduate Studies UiTM verifies that **Shehryar Muhammad** is in **Semester 2**. His current academic status is **'Active'** for academic session of **March 2024 - August 2024**. The validity of this letter is for the above mentioned semester only. For your information, the medium of instruction for postgraduate programmes in UiTM is **English**.

4. For further information about this student, please contact the Head of Programme at **03 - 5544 8315** or the Institute of Graduate Studies office at **03-55448322/ 55438491/ 55438559/ 55438480**.

Thank you.

اوسها، تقوى، موليا
"MALAYSIA MADANI"
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Yours faithfully,

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